

Don't Just Work Hard, Work Smart: Strategize Smart, Featuring Sue Nokes

Sue Nokes, Advisory Board Vice Chairman, Asurion; Former Chief Customer & Operations Officer, T-Mobile

Hard work is fundamental to success; but without a game plan, it's useless. No one could work harder than my friend, Pat Summitt. But what really gave Pat the winning edge was her ability to combine smart habits with a clear strategy.

Pat said, "While I preach hard work, I also preach smart work. What do I mean by smart work? I mean the combination of efficiency and effectiveness that will help you succeed without wasted motion and with perspective. Smart work is a matter of sizing up the job that has to be done and deciding on the best way of doing it."

Pat had a vision, clear strategy, and goals, and she worked hard to get everybody's buy-in. When you work smart, you put yourself in a position to get the most out of your time and energy. Before throwing yourself at a project or a task, establish clear goals. By pinpointing what you want to achieve together, you create focused energy.

Gather your team and ask, "What are we trying to achieve together? What does success look like?" Be clear about what success is and, almost as important, what it isn't.

Once you have a goal, outline a detailed plan which includes measures of success; make sure everyone knows next steps; understand the path forward from the outset. Otherwise, you'll run in circles and waste valuable energy in the process. Pat learned how to prioritize what needed to be done by asking, "What are the foundational things we need to get done and get right first?"

Peak performance doesn't just happen. It needs to be built and cultivated along the way. When you get to the championship game or that key meeting with a client, it's not the time to worry about preparation. It's the time to use your muscle memory and focus on execution.

To fully utilize your team's capabilities, assign clear roles to each team member. Over time, Pat learned that it was better to break down responsibilities among the coaching staff by assigning them each to a specific area to focus their attention on during the game so that she could focus on making executive decisions.

If you're looking for a game plan to help your team to deliver peak performance, employ a smart strategy with a coherent plan that has clear goals and defined roles. If you've done the right preparation, when it's game time in sports, business, or in life, rely on muscle memory, your preparation, and focus on execution to deliver the win.

